

Cliffords Inn

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THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

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The Hall of the original Cliffords Inn



Cliffords Inn Galehouse



View from the lower of St Dunstan in the West

Clifford's Inn is the ancient name now attached to an eight storey mansion block built in 1934, which occupies less than half of the site of the original Inn of Chancery. The building now contains over 100 flats above offices on the lower floors.

The previous Clifford's Inn stretched from Fetter Lane to Chancery Lane. The entrance was from Fleet Street through a gatehouse in Clifford's Inn Passage, and the gatehouse is the sole surviving part of the early buildings.

The original Clifford's Inn was founded in 1344, when Isabel de Clifford rented it to be used as an Inn of Chancery. As an Inn of Chancery it provided accommodation for the first stage of the education of students of law, who would continue their studies at one of the Inns of Court before being called as lawyers to the Bar. Clifford's Inn was one of a number of Inns of Chancery. The others (Clement's, Lyons', Thavie's, Furnival's, Barnard's, Staple's, Lincoln's, Gray's, Strand and New) were all founded later and were wound up earlier. Their educational functions ceased in 1642 upon the outbreak of the Civil War. However, Clifford's Inn continued as a professional association with residential accommodation and a hall.

After the Great Fire of London in 1666, the Fire Court was based in Clifford's Inn. Its function was to adjudicate over responsibility for building repairs for, while most of the buildings of London were on full repairing leases, most tenants were in no position to rebuild the properties.

The Fire Court had sixteen judges, of whom just three were a quorum, with draconian powers to decide which of the parties involved should rebuild structures, and to settle boundary disputes.

An account published in 1912 shows that the residents of Clifford's Inn were engaged in a wide variety of trades and professions: literary work, sculpture, painting, architecture, theatre management, law, shorthand, typing, photography and tailoring. Cliffords Inn has a number of literary associations. It was mentioned in three of the novels of Charles Dickens. Leonard and Virginia Woolf rented a room in Clifford's Inn in 1912 when they returned from their honeymoon, and took all their meals at the Old Cock Tavern, which still exists on Fleet Street. Clifford's Inn was the headquarters of organisations including The Art-Workers' Guild, The Positivist Society, The London Typographical Society, and The Society of Women Journalists. Subsequently The Imperial Society of Knights Bachelor bought the Hall and some of the surrounding buildings.

Over time, the buildings of Clifford's Inn deteriorated, the professional association became moribund, and in 1900 it was decided to sell the site and to give the proceeds to the Attorney General for the benefit of legal education. The sale was however delayed until 1934, when the site was split and the buildings (save the gatehouse) demolished. The Chancery Lane frontage was sold to an insurance company, another large part sold to the Crown, while the current Cliffords Inn was built as serviced flats.